

# The Verdon Gorge

*A spectacular river-cut gorge in the South of France, referred to by some as the European Grand Canyon*



The Verdon Gorge is a deep river canyon in the limestone massifs of the alpine foothills straddling the Alpes-de-Haute-Provence and Var regions of southeastern France. The gorge lies on a 15-mile (25-km) stretch of the Verdon river, which has carved the gorge over the last several thousand years. The river's striking turquoise-green color, produced by glacial rock flour suspended in the water, gives the river and gorge their name: *vert* means "green" in French. At the end of the canyon, the river flows into the artificial Lake Sainte-Croix.

## Limestone walls

The width of the gorge at river level ranges from 20 ft (6 m) to 330 ft (100 m), and on each side steep cliffs reach up to 2,300 ft (700 m) tall. The limestone rock in which the Verdon Gorge formed was laid down during the Triassic Period (252–201 million years ago) when the area was under an ocean. Subsequent episodes of tectonic uplift and rock fracturing, followed by a period of glaciation, prepared the landscape for the river to carve out the gorge as it is today.



## ◁ LUSH VALLEY

The bottom of the gorge, which has a mild and humid microclimate, is covered in lush vegetation that diminishes with elevation up the cliff face.

# Lake Geneva

*A large alpine lake on the French–Swiss border, once hit by a huge tsunami*



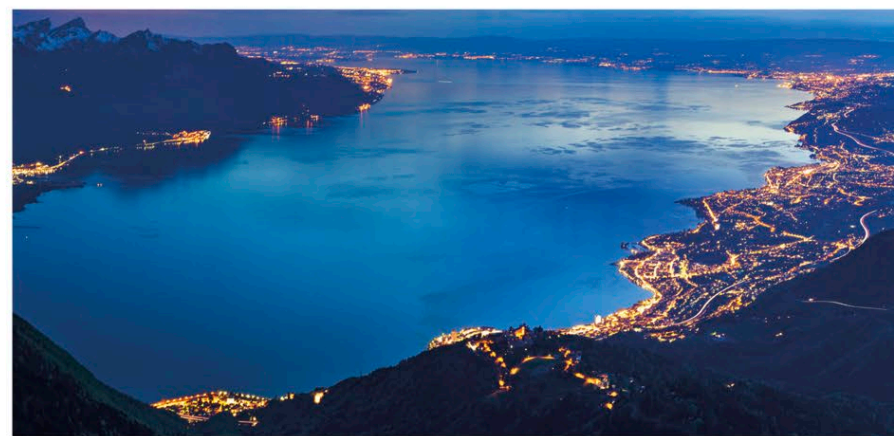
Known as Lac Léman in France, Lake Geneva is a crescent-shaped lake on the northern side of the Alps, stretching along the border between southeastern France and southwestern Switzerland. The largest of the alpine lakes, it is 45 miles (73 km) long, up to 9 miles (14 km) wide, and has a shoreline of just over 120 miles (200 km).

## Lake of two halves

Lake Geneva lies on the course of the Rhône River, which enters through a delta at its eastern end and leaves at the western end through the city of Geneva. The lake is geographically divided into two basins separated by the Strait of Promenthoux. The Large Lake, to the east, is the widest section, and reaches a maximum depth of 1,020 ft (310 m). The Small Lake, to the west, is much narrower and shallower. Lake Geneva is notable for its rhythmical fluctuations in water level, known as seiches, caused by strong winds and rapid changes in atmospheric pressure.

## ▷ BUSY SHORES

The shores of Lake Geneva are home to more than 1 million people, including the residents of Lausanne and Geneva.



## THE LAKE GENEVA TSUNAMI

Historical accounts and evidence from the lakebed suggest that Lake Geneva was struck by a large tsunami in 563 CE. Thought to have been caused by a rock fall near the Rhône Delta, a wave up to 52 ft (16 m) high traveled the length of the lake, devastating the shorelines in its wake. Moving at speeds of up to 45 mph (70 kph), the wave would have reached Geneva in just over an hour.

